

film reviews

Fast, Furious, Fun

CHAK DE INDIA

Director: Shimit Amin
Starring: Shah Rukh Khan, Sagarika Ghatge, Shilpa Shukla

"Iss team ka sabse bada gunda main hoon", says Shah Rukh Khan's hockey coach to a particularly nettlesome senior player in *Chak De India*'s Indian women's hockey team. He is also the film's *sabse-bada*-asset. In a sea of hockey-twirling Rambo-leenas, Khan keeps it subtle, exhorting and attacking in equal measures but never stealing the game away from 16



Khan with his team wonderfully cast girls. It is fitting that the ultimate romantic hero of the '90s should anchor the most feisty girl power movie to have come out of Bollywood ever. The girls, from the truculent Haryanvi Komal to the an-

gry Bindiya, from the hefty Punjabi Balbir to the very proper Chandigarh *ki kudi* Preeti, may be drawn from stereotypes but they shatter them with aggressive performances, staring Khan in the eye, almost defeating the Indian men's hockey team, assaulting a

gang of boys and showing the six-time Australian team a thing or two about how to win. The girls, almost all of them beginner actors, underwent a four-month training course, learning to play hockey, act and speak in different dialects. The effort shows. The game is shot like ice hockey, fast, furious, fantastic, with each swing and dribble choreographed according to the storyboard—clearly Amin is keeping his thriller instinct alive (his first film was the taut *Ab Tak Chappan*). You need *niyat* (intention), not *takat* (raw power) to make a team, says Khan's coach to the girls. This film has *niyat* and *takat*. And sheer joy.

Scene Stealer

THE BLUE UMBRELLA

Director: Vishal Bharadwaj
Starring: Pankaj Kapur, Shreya Sharma

In a tiny town of Himachal Pradesh, a *jagran* is going on. The tune is borrowed from "You are my Sonia" in *Kabhi Khushi Kabhie Gham* but the song is devotional. In another part of the town, a group of Japanese tourists takes a

fancy to a little girl's exotic neckpiece—she gives it but only after extracting a price. Bharadwaj is not only an acute observer of children (his delightful *Makdee* is proof of it) but also of the tiny dots on India's map that make up the heart of the nation. His depiction of the petty little jealousies, the inevitable reconciliations, and the little rivalries is exquisite. Based on a Ruskin Bond short story, this is the kind of warm-



Kapur with Sharma hearted film which makes you reach out for a cup of hot tea and a plate of steaming samosas on a

cold winter's day. Each frame of the film is visual perfection, the colours bright, and the acting note perfect.

Corny Caravan

KAAFILA

Director: Ammtoje Mann
Starring: Ammtoje Mann, Sunny Deol

Is there anything worse than Sunny Deol screaming his guts out at sundry extras in a paper-thin characterisation of a patriotic Indian? Yes, when he does so as a patriotic



Deol as Pakistani soldier

Pakistani soldier. In the misguided *Kaafila*, which is loosely based on the Malta boat tragedy, a rag-tag group of illegal immigrants tries to get to England, but seems to spend all the time circling Kabul and Dushanbe. When they are not dancing with Ukrainian extras, dying of extreme cold and uttering what sounds suspiciously like "roohafza"

to their Afghan counterparts, the ugliest bunch of people ever cast in a movie keep mooning about their families back home. There is a message of India-Pakistan harmony somewhere in this mess, but no one, not even the most devoted advocates of Track II, can be expected to have the patience for it.

by Kaveri Bamzai